Israel didn't colonize. It came home.

A one-page cheat sheet from @noamroz__. Short facts, sources at the bottom.

The facts

1. **"West Bank" is a new name.** It came from Arabic ad-Diffah al-Gharbiyyah, the "Western Bank" of the Jordan. Jordan took the area in 1948 to 1949 and annexed it in 1950, naming it the West Bank. Before that, English maps and even the 1947 UN partition plan said "Judea" and "Samaria". [1] [2]
2. **Judea means the land of Judah.** "Judea" is the Greek and Roman form of the Hebrew Yehudah. The word "Jew" comes from Yehudi, "of Judah". The name of the land and the name of the people are the same word. [2] [3]
3. **Samaria is Shomron, a city built about 880 BCE.** King Omri of Israel bought the hill from Shemer and built his capital there (1 Kings 16:24). That is close to 2,900 years ago. [4]
4. **Hebrew is native to this land.** It is a Canaanite language of the Southern Levant, spoken by the Israelites, written here from the 10th century BCE, and revived as a spoken language in the 19th century. It is the only country where Hebrew is official. [5]
5. **Jews never fully left.** Long before modern Zionism (1881), the "Old Yishuv" kept a continuous Jewish presence in Jerusalem, Hebron, Safed and Tiberias. [6]
6. **Real empires look different.** Colonizers sailed far from home, ruled other peoples and spread their language across continents:

Empire	Peak area	Language today	Official in
British Empire	35.5M km² (1920)	English, 1,530M speakers	58 countries
Spanish Empire	13.7M km² (1810)	Spanish, 561M	20 countries
Umayyad Caliphate (Arab conquests)	11.1M km² (720)	Standard Arabic, 335M	24 countries
French colonial empire	11.5M km² (1920)	French, 334M	26 countries
Portuguese Empire	not shown (sources disagree)	Portuguese, 269M	9 countries
Israel	**not on any empire list**	**Hebrew, about 10M**	**1 country**

   Areas: Rein Taagepera's estimates. Speakers: Ethnologue 2026. [7] [8]

   Dates for the reel: Arab conquest of North Africa 647 to 709 CE; Spain and Portugal split the Americas at Tordesillas in 1494; Britain ruled India 1757 to 1947; France invaded Algeria in 1830 and ruled until 1962. [9] [10] [11] [12]
7. **The Genesis 15:18 note.** The Bible describes a land promised "from the river of Egypt unto the great river, the river Euphrates". Scholars disagree on what "river of Egypt" means: the Nile is a traditional reading, but most modern scholars point to Wadi el-Arish in Sinai (some to Nahal Besor). It is a biblical text, not a border claim. Today's Israel is a small fraction of that area. [13] [14]
8. **In my view:** you can't colonize your own homeland. We were exiled and we came back. We want to live in part of it, in peace, and keep building things the whole world uses: drip irrigation, navigation apps, medicine, chips.

   Quick honesty notes: Israel has used "Judea and Samaria" officially since 1967, and the term is linked to the Israeli right; "West Bank" is the term in the Oslo Accords. The names Judea and Samaria were in use for millennia, but not as the official name the whole time (Rome renamed the province Syria Palaestina after 135 CE). [1] [2]

Sources

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